did not want it to be too overt, “We could put the program under the guise of training.” Finally, he believed that the US should go ahead regardless of what London decided to do. If the US held off any longer, it might “jeopardize the developing relationship between the US and India.” His bottom line was “It is hard to see how we can stop the Chinese Communists without India.”[78]

At a subsequent meeting in May, when McNamara outlined the potential consequences of giving India a commitment, Kennedy reiterated that the US could not let India fall to Chinese aggression. It would even use nuclear weapons if necessary in the course of defending India. Because, he asserted, if the US was willing to let China defeat India, then there was little point in the American effort to shore up South Korea and South Vietnam.[79]

On a visit to India in May, Rusk tried to reassure Nehru, noting that “there was not the slightest reason to doubt US sympathy and support to India in its conflict with China.… If India is again attacked by the Chinese, the US is and will remain India’s friend.” There was “no question about that” because any such attack would have broader repercussions. Nehru, on his part, acknowledged the possibility that China would not attack India over the next few months, but asserted he could not be sanguine about the threat over time. He told Rusk that he “continue[d] to feel the heavy pressure of further prospective Chinese aggression.”[80]

Lobbying for American aid, Indian policymakers highlighted the threat and the stakes for the US. Visiting the US, T. T. Krishnamachari, now minister of economic and defense coordination, observed to Kennedy that Beijing’s hostility toward India was unlikely to dissipate. There could be Chinese subversion in India’s northeast and China could encircle India by subverting or coopting the countries on India’s periphery. Krishnamachari also said that if China attacked again, it would use its air force, which it had not done in the 1962 war. Indian retaliation would then lead to a Chinese attack on Indian cities. Krishnamachari outlined the consequences for Indian security and political stability—and, by implication, for the US—of the government’s inability to protect its cities. In a meeting with Kennedy, Indian President Sarvepalli (S.) Radhakrishnan asserted that China was trying to send a geopolitical message to Southeast Asia, as well as an ideological message about the superiority of the Chinese “way of life” rather than the Indian “democratic way of life.” He emphasized, “The